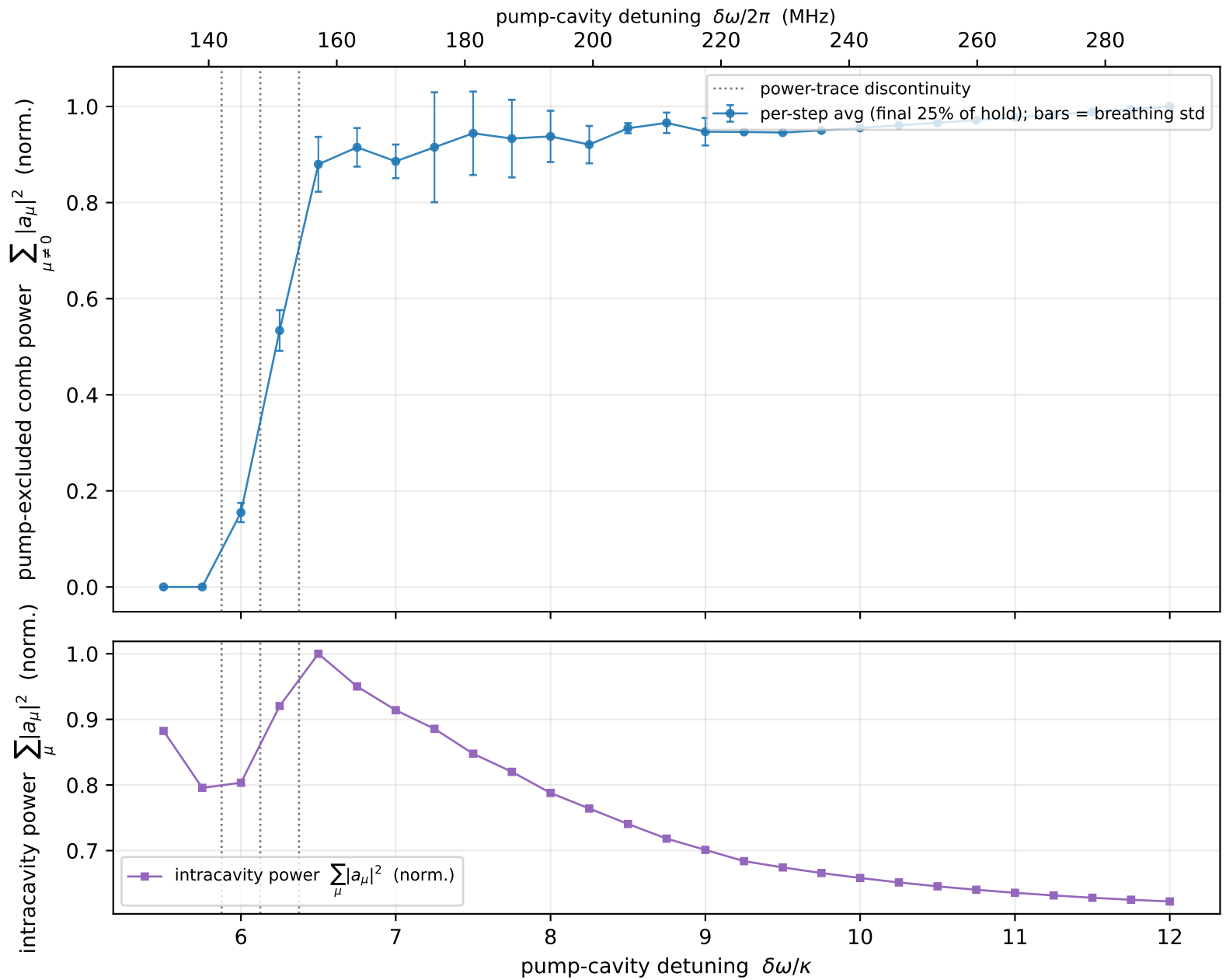




5-soliton staircase, $p_{in} = 0.214$ W, $n_{\tau} = 4096$. Deterministic symmetry-broken seed (position_seed=1, jitter=0.25) at 12κ , warm continuation swept DOWN, hold 2000 RT/step, averaged over the final 25% (cycle-averages the breather). Thermo-optic model ON (deterministic, noise off). The solitons annihilate sequentially at the branch's lower edge -- the staircase; the final 1->0 annihilation is power-muted in the TOTAL power and must not be forced to register as a power step. Dotted lines mark first-difference discontinuities of the plotted primary trace. Raw data, no smoothing.